Uttar Pradesh too shows various domesticated and wild animals and other fauna—cattle, sheep/goat, pig, various varieties of deer, wild boar, three species of turtles, and at least two species of fish.[44] The ancient city of Rajghat in the Varanasi district suggests a reduction in animal species over time, from the time period of 600–400 BCE to 400–200 BCE.[45] While in the first sub-period a total of fifteen species were represented, the numbers came down to about nine. Among the species present earlier but not in Mauryan times was fish (*Teleost*). The time period, though, for which the abrupt reduction in species has been suggested includes the time of Ashoka but is not limited to it. So there is no way of working out the results of Ashoka's exhortations against animal slaughter.

If this edict is read along with the measures for animal welfare in the earlier rock edicts, what stands out is the sheer comprehensiveness of Ashoka's intentions. He lists every variety of cruelty in order to express his abhorrence. The regulation of animal castration becomes an imperial obsession: this is nothing short of jaw-dropping. One does not know about methods of animal castration in ancient India, but if the crude methods followed in rural India are anything to go by, the painful crushing of testicles or the removal of testicles of animals through the 'open method' will have been practised, the pain being unimaginable.[46] Veterinary facilities too become an important part of state activity, as does the enforcing of 'closed seasons' to protect breeding. Normally, the state protects fauna when numbers decline.[47] The language and idiom of Ashoka's concern is radically different: it is a code of ahimsa, or non-violence. It was as if Ashoka's own self-image as a morally credible monarch involved laying down a humane code of conduct towards all living creatures.

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